parliament, the Lok Sabha, ‘The prime minister is no more. The light is out.’ Subramaniam was paraphrasing Nehru’s own statement after the assassination of Mahatma Gandhi on 30 January 1948: ‘The light has gone out of our lives and there is darkness everywhere.’[28]

Although India had received some assistance from the West during the war, American and British offers of military aid came with strings attached. As the Indian historian Gyanesh Kudaisya points out in his account of Nehru’s last days,

> Nehru was upset…India was now forced to accept outside mediation and to open a dialogue with Pakistan over the highly contentious issue of Kashmir. Both the US and UK governments had used the Himalayan crisis to put pressure on India to make concessions to Pakistan and to settle the Kashmir issue. Nehru’s carefully nurtured policy of non-alignment suffered a setback and India’s stature on the global stage, which he had worked so hard to build, diminished.[29]

Gulzarilal Nanda, an economist and a politician from the Congress Party, took over as interim prime minister until Lal Bahadur Shastri could be sworn in on 9 June. A former freedom fighter of some renown, Shastri was far from an unknown figure in Indian politics, but he was mild-mannered, soft-spoken, and lacked Nehru’s charisma and stature on the world stage.

Nevertheless, he led India during the 1965 war with Pakistan, which the Indian Army won, and thus managed to restore some of the pride that had been lost in 1962. On 10 January 1966, a peace deal was signed in Tashkent in Uzbekistan, then a part of the Soviet Union. The Soviet Premier Alexei Kosygin moderated the meeting between Shastri and Pakistan’s President Muhammed Ayub Khan. A day later, Shastri died from a sudden heart attack, which has led to all kinds of conspiracy theories. Was he poisoned and, if so, by whom? But there was never any evidence to confirm those speculations and Shastri’s body was flown back to India to be cremated there.

Gulzarilal Nanda had to step in again and served as the acting head of the government until 24 January, when India got another new prime minister who would raise the country’s profile in the region and across the world: Nehru’s then 48-year-old daughter Indira Gandhi. Relations with Washington would become strained because of her criticism of the American bombing of Vietnam. She also steered India into a close